But it isn’t absence that causes sorrow. It is affection and love. Without affection, without love, such absences would cause us no pain. For this reason, even the pain caused by absence is, in the end, something good and even beautiful, because it feeds on that which gives meaning to life.

Bryce, I met in London, on the first occasion that I went to seek out a group working on quantum gravity. I was a young novice, fascinated by this arcane subject that no one in Italy was working on; he was its grand guru. I had gone to Imperial College to meet up with Chris Isham, and when I arrived I was told that he was on the top-floor terrace. Sitting together at a small table up there, I found Chris Isham, Karel Kuchar, and Bryce DeWitt—the three main authors whose ideas I had been studying in recent years. I remember vividly the intense impression I had on seeing them there through the glass, calmly discussing among themselves. I did not dare to interrupt. They seemed to me like three great Zen masters exchanging unfathomable truths between enigmatic smiles.

They were probably only deciding where to go for dinner. Revisiting and reflecting on the episode, I realize that at the time they were younger than I am now. This, too, is time: a strange shifting of perspective. Shortly before he died, Bryce gave a long interview in Italy, subsequently published in a small book.[73] And it was only then I became aware that he’d followed my work much more closely, and with more sympathy, than I had ever suspected from our conversations together, in which he was more prone to express criticism than encouragement.

John and Bryce were my spiritual fathers. Thirsting, I found in their ideas fresh, clear water to drink. So, thank you, John; thanks, Bryce. As human beings, we live by emotions and thoughts. We exchange them when we are in the same place at the same time, talking to each other, looking into each other’s eyes, brushing against each other’s skin. We are nourished by this network of encounters and exchanges. But, in reality, we do not need to be in the same place and time to have such exchanges. Thoughts and emotions that create bonds of attachment between us have no difficulty in crossing seas and decades, sometimes even centuries, tied to thin sheets of paper or dancing between the microchips of a computer. We are part of a network that goes far beyond the few days of our lives and the few square meters that we tread. This book is also a part of that weave. . . .

But I have digressed and lost my thread. Nostalgia for John and Bryce has caused me to deviate from my path. All I had intended to say in this chapter is that they had discovered the extremely simple structure of the equation that describes the dynamics of the world. It describes possible events and the correlations between them, and nothing else.